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Miners Open Season—

Pitching Question For Andy

The outlook for the 1972 baseball season at U.T.-El Paso hinges upon the pitching.

And it won't take long for Coach Andy Cohen to make an appraisal, as his Miners inaugurate the season Saturday when they host Ranger Junior College (1 p.m.) in a double-header at Dudley Field.

"We have a lot of strong arms, but need to gain experience," said Cohen. "As the pitching goes, so will go our team."

GONE IS ace southpaw Marc Bombard, who finished third in final NCAA statistics in seasonal victories—12, also a school record. Marc led the club in most departments, excluding most walks issued, and had 109 innings pitched and won all six of U.T.-El Paso's Western Athletic Conference victories in '71.

Cohen has only two experienced pitchers—Phil Darwin and Ernie Carreon. However, things aren't as bad in other areas. Cohen is extremely pleased with the depth, saying "it's the best in many years."

Miner prospects, by position:

PITCHING: Question mark. Cohen has but two lettermen returning. Righthander Phil Darwin posted a 1-4 record a year ago while senior Ernie Carreon had a 1-1 record.

Several youngsters showed promise during preseason workouts. Service veteran Tony Eaton, a lefty, figures to be a starter. Southpaw Terry Williams, a freshman from Florida, has a sore shoulder, but is slated to see a lot of action when well. Frank Del Toro and Joel Kuentsler have looked good.

The biggest transition is moving Tim Peden, first string catcher last season, to the mound. Peden has a strong right arm and good size (6-3, 210) and showed good progress in pre-season drill. Others vying for spots include Richard Taeger, Mike Beltran, Ray Gregerson, Bob Knox and Gilbert Rodriguez.

INFIELD: Good. Andy is pleased with the speed and agility of the candidates, which is much improved over a year ago. The biggest battle for a starting job is being waged at third base between Jan Hood and Max Swafford. Both are good fielders, but Hood perhaps swings a stronger bat.

At shortstop letterman Ernie Hernandez is fighting to keep his job against Larry Hunnicutt and Bob Hess. Returning letterman Terry Baker seems to have a hold on second base although Cuck Garcia has looked good.

Junior letterman Barry Alburtt will start at first base and is backed by Frank Del Toro and Joel Kuentsler. Infield depth will be supplied by Eloy Alvarado and Bob Morales, both of whom can also play the outfield.

OUTFIELD: Inexperienced, but quicker. Gone are Bob Prokopowicz and Brian Harper. Prokopowicz was the ninth leading hitter in the nation last year with a .422 average, while Harper swung the bat at a .381 clip and was fourth in the nation with 19 doubles.

Cohen hopes his newly acquired speed will make up for the losses. Centerfield could become Malcolm McClean's property. He covers plenty of ground and showed in pre-season he can swing the bat.

Joe Pennies could be a starter at any position and Lail Maldonado had a fine spring in left field. Other candidates are Joel Kuentsler and Frank Del Toro, also slated for mound duty, and Joe Hernandez, former Austin High standout.

CATCHING: Weaker. "We're hurting somewhat because we are trying to convert Tim Peden into a pitcher," said Cohen. Peden had three years experience behind the plate, but his arm may be needed more on the mound.

Clint Newsome, two-year letterman, is heading the list for the catcher's spot. Also on hand are Ernie Hernandez and Eloy Alvarado.